says Maurya. ‘We had many Q-and-As here where we put our views before the public and these conversations had a big impact.’[54]

Essentially, the BJP under Amit Shah replicated the booth-level political organisation lessons that the party had learnt in Gujarat. Dinesh Sharma, who had served as party secretary in Gujarat with Shah, before moving back to the UP unit, attributes the entire post-2013 shift in the state’s party organisation to Shah. When I asked him whether the BJP was replicating the Gujarat organisational model in UP, he concurred. ‘This is correct that in Gujarat we had a sangathan up to the booth level and the primary basis of our victories in Gujarat was the sangathan,’ he said. ‘Today we have the same situation in Uttar Pradesh too. We have a sangathan till the booth level and the basis of our victory is the sangathan. Whoever the sangathan puts up is the candidate. Earlier it was that if you don’t put so and so person, then the party will get finished. Now whether you put Mister A or Mister B from a particular place, it doesn’t matter —in the Gujarat style … We did this in Gujarat … We all keep contributing a little bit like squirrels, but victory is the result of our combined hard work.’[55]

Shah, he says, focused attention from 2013 onwards on bringing in a new generation of youth workers into the party. This was at the heart of the BJP’s turnaround. ‘The person who gave the organisation a new character as the creator was Amit Shah,’ he says. ‘His Chanakya-neeti created workers in every booth and not just workers, spirited workers. This created a large group of youth who had a feeling of dedication to the party.’[56]

Crucially, the BJP focused on building a middle line of leadership in the districts, with a new line-up of Backward Caste leaders. The key thing with some of the smaller Backward Castes is that, while they may be small in numbers, many of them are heavily concentrated in specific constituencies. When they embraced the BJP, it made a huge difference to winnability. For example, Mohanlalganj in Lucknow is a Pasi-dominated seat and Pasis are the most dominant SC caste after Jatavs in UP’s Awadh region. So, the BJP specifically focused on building a Pasi leadership, with leaders like Kaushal Kishore, who won the parliamentary election from Mohanlalganj in 2019 and heads the BJP’s state SC unit. Similarly,